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Laughter as Gesture: Hilarity and the Anti-Sublime

Stephen G Nichols

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 Stephen G. Nichols
 Johns Hopkins University

*But one thing I do know,
 O Zarathustra: Whoever
 would kill most thoroughly, laughs.*

—Nietzsche

Recently I ran across an article on laughter that said it wanted to examine ‘uses of laughter in the literal sense of the word.’¹ The author clearly meant that he wanted to discuss the act of laughter, but that’s not what he said; and, however unconscious his choice of terms, ‘the literal sense of laughter’ was over-determined. Sense connotes ‘meaning,’ and it is precisely the meaning of laughter, meaning *in* laughter, not to mention *theories* of laughter that thinkers have been trying to pin down since antiquity.

> The beginning is a feeling of the 'I' that, in every possible gesture and especially in each

> On a very basic level the unity of the body provides for the identity that is necessary, but deception, not to mention everyday inconsistency, are constantly posing a threat to it.[~10]

> always the gesture of being at a loss in language; it is always a 'gag' in the literal sense

> In an art theater proper, one rarely sees an actor who can really walk and stand. As a matter

* And now they look at me and laugh: and as they laugh, they even hate me. There is ice in t
 * I would believe only in a god who could dance. And when I saw my devil I found him serious
 * Still is the bottom of my sea. Who would guess that it harbors sportive monsters? Imperturb
 * And yet he has not learned laughter or beauty. Gloomy this hunter returned from the woods
 * Then laughter surrounded me. Alas how the laughter tore my entrails and slit open my heart
 * And as Zarathustra was speaking thus he laughed at himself in melancholy and bitterness.
 * Laugh, laugh, my bright, wholesome sarcasm. From high mountains cast down your glittering

Notes

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Stephen G. Nichols, James M. Beall Professor of French and Humanities and Chair, Romance Languages, at Johns Hopkins University, is currently completing a book entitled *Gothic and Guillotine: Building History in Restoration France*. A longer version of this article will appear in *Laughing Matters: On the Anthropology of Laughter* to be published in 2004.

¹Stephen Halliwell, ‘The Uses of Laughter in Greek Literature,’ *Classical Quarterly*, N.

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